PROF. CHRISTINA M. WALLACE ▶
Senior Lecturer of Business Administration, Entrepreneurial Management Unit, Harvard Business School

SURVIVING WAR & AI

A degree in math and theatre, the start of a career at the Metropolitan Opera, then to building several start-ups, Christina Wallace has always thought of herself as "a human Venn diagram" who works at the intersection of business, technology and the arts. That inter-disciplinary approach, she told the gathering at the India Today conclave, can stand individuals and businesses in good stead at a time when the world is changing not every generation or every few years, but every week. Given how much we conflate our identity with our job titles, any disruption, she said, can rob us of both "in one conversation". Which is why if your identity is rooted in multiple experiences and networks, it is easier to pivot when crisis strikes.

At the same time, Christina urged organisations to build innovation ecosystems rather than play at innovation theatre, "to actually build new businesses that can become the future of business".

Audiences were treated to another fascinating insight when Christina said you can have a life portfolio like you have a finance portfolio, where you reallocate assets based on the "season of life you are in". So, there may be a season when work will be 70 per cent, or another where family will be 50 per cent. That is when, she said, your moonlighting project, your hobby, can become your day job. Citing her own example, she said she checks in at the end of the year whether she had more good days or bad. "If the answer is no, it's time to make a shift." ■

"I hate the term work-life balance; it puts work and life in opposition to each other when your work is in the context of your life

In the age of AI, storytelling is the last human job. AI can do formulaic things; it is not creative



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **In a world where you can't see what's coming next, planning for 5-10 years is obsolete. Instead use what's called an emergent strategy. Take one step, assess, then plan the next step**
- **Even in a constantly changing world, it is better to take action than stand still**
- **Expire your data. Constantly update information to keep up with the times**
- **Silos don't work as they follow specific goals, not a customer-centric approach**
- **Don't ignore AI altogether, it's incredibly useful in communications**